

of overhauling of the top-rung of the state's bureaucracy and police set-up, suggesting that Kumar was perhaps looking to take a fresh guard for the remaining 32 months of his tenure.

But it hasn't taken long for the rumblings to begin. The axed health minister Chandra Mohan Rai, leading the pack of BJP dissidents is demanding an explanation for his ouster. "I was the best performer. Sushil Modi should kindly explain on what basis I was dropped," Rai says, adding that "Modi's pursuit for power would sink BJP in Bihar." Another axed BJP minister Janardan Singh Sigriwal has also wondered aloud over the logic behind his ouster, which, according to Rai, was done to please JD(U) MP Prabhunath Singh, who has no love lost for Sigriwal. Similarly, BJP veterans like Ashwini Choubey and Nand Kishore Yadav—considered to be among the most efficient ministers in a cabinet in which efficiency was at a premium—are unhappy because the recent reshuffle has seen their wings

clipped. Choubey was urban development and housing minister but has been shifted to the relatively insignificant portfolio of public health engineering ministry while Yadav who held the twin portfolios of road construction and tourism, is now the health minister. Both are seething with rage and command enough support to cause some damage. The trouble, as one observer puts it, is Kumar's belief that he is the JD(U). True, Kumar has grown in strength after the marginalisation of George Fernandes, who has been replaced as party chief by Sharad Yadav, thanks to Kumar's support. Yadav, currently a Rajya Sabha MP from Bihar, is considered too dependent upon the chief minister to challenge his decisions.

The unrest within the coalition in Patna

is coupled with growing discontent at BJP headquarters in Delhi which feels slighted by the chief minister's cavalier attitude towards its coalition partner. BJP has not taken kindly to the fact that Kumar rarely calls coalition members for discussions. It is also aware that while Kumar waxes eloquent about development mantra, hardly any has taken place during his regime. Titans of Indian industry routinely visit the state on Kumar's invitation but seldom show any willingness

to risk their money in the impoverished state. Also Kumar's personal feud with Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav is holding up some of the projects that the latter, a former state chief minister, had chalked out. Just the perfect poll fodder for Lalu when elections come around once again. ■

JD(U), which he rules with an iron fist, has quietly acquiesced, but BJP is annoyed that it was not consulted.



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